

Hydration and Workout Nutrition

Hydration

Water is necessary for:

- circulation;
- temperature regulation;
- digestion;
- cellular processes;
- exercise performance.

Hydration needs vary according to:

- body size;
- climate;
- temperature;
- humidity;
- exercise duration;
- exercise intensity;
- diet;
- individual sweat rate.

There is no single perfect water target for every person.

Useful everyday habits include:

- drinking regularly through the day;
- drinking with meals;
- responding to thirst;
- increasing fluid intake during exercise or hot weather.

Urine colour can provide a rough practical clue to hydration, but it is not a medical test.

Hydration During Exercise

For many ordinary gym sessions, water is sufficient.

Longer exercise sessions, heavy sweating or training in hot conditions may increase the need for:

- additional fluid;
- sodium;
- electrolytes;
- carbohydrate.

Extremely high water intake over a short period can be dangerous because it can dilute blood sodium.

Pre-Workout Nutrition

The purpose of a pre-workout meal is to provide energy and allow comfortable training.

A useful pre-workout meal can contain:

- carbohydrate;
- protein;
- fluid;
- moderate or low amounts of fat depending on timing.

Meals eaten close to exercise are often easier to tolerate when they contain less:

- fat;
- very high fibre;
- extremely spicy foods;
- very heavy foods.

Example pre-workout options include:

- banana with curd or yogurt;
- oats with milk and fruit;
- rice with a lean protein source;
- roti with eggs;
- fruit with a protein shake.

There is no mandatory pre-workout food.

Nutrition During Exercise

For many gym sessions lasting around one hour, water is usually enough.

For prolonged or high-volume exercise, nutrition during exercise can become more important.

Depending on duration and intensity, this may include:

- fluid;
- carbohydrate;
- electrolytes.

Endurance-fuelling needs depend on:

- event duration;
- training intensity;
- gastrointestinal tolerance;
- sweat losses.

Post-Workout Nutrition

Post-workout nutrition supports:

- recovery;
- muscle-protein synthesis;
- glycogen restoration;
- rehydration.

A practical post-workout meal usually contains:

- protein;
- carbohydrate;
- fluid.

Examples include:

- rice, dal and curd;
- chicken with rice and vegetables;
- eggs with roti and fruit;
- paneer with rice or roti;
- tofu with rice;
- whey protein with fruit followed by a normal meal.

A protein supplement is not required immediately after exercise if a normal protein-containing meal is available.

Electrolytes

Electrolytes include minerals such as:

- sodium;
- potassium;
- chloride;
- magnesium.

Electrolyte drinks can be useful when:

- exercise is prolonged;
- sweat losses are high;
- training occurs in hot environments;
- both fluid and sodium need to be replaced.

Short ordinary gym sessions do not automatically require a commercial electrolyte product.